



Lucky Castaway

STRANDED WITH
A SLOT MACHINE

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Elevator Pitch

After days lost at sea, you wash ashore - right beside a mysterious slot machine!

Soon you find out that your survival depends on the pull of its lever.

Gather resources and craft new items to create powerful synergies that help you stay alive against all odds.

In *Lucky Castaway (working title)*, strategic deckbuilding and a flexible crafting system meet the unpredictable excitement of the slot machine, creating a playful survival adventure.

Key Information

The following table presents key information about the project.

Platform	Steam (Windows, Linux, Mac)
Player Count	Singleplayer
Genre	Strategy, Deckbuilder, Roguelite, Indie
Planned Release	Q3 2026
Monetization	Premium, CHF 11.-
Estimated Playtime	10 hours on average. Replayable beyond that due to the Roguelite nature of the game and achievements for completionists.
Game Engine	Unity 6

Unique Selling Points

Lucky Castaway is a “slot machine roguelike”, which is a young subgenre of more traditional roguelike deckbuilders. It takes inspiration from existing games in that space like *Luck be a Landlord*, but innovates on the formula:

- A flexible crafting system
- A slot machine brimming with personality, that even serves as a map
- A lighthearted take on the castaway theme
- A charming art style that sets it apart from other games in the subgenre, which are often more minimalistic

The Team

The team consists of Philipp Gröbelbauer and Sven Kristlbauer. The two connected at a “Find your Team” event at the Swiss Game Hub and decided to work together.

Philipp Gröbelbauer

Philipp has a degree in computer science, a few years of experience as a developer, and a strong passion for Game Design. He had been a hobby game developer for over a decade, before deciding to go full-time in January 2025. He recently founded his own company *Rare Crab Studio GmbH* and is excited to be working on his first commercial game.

Roles: Programming
 Game Design
 Project Management

Portfolio: <https://ohoodie.itch.io>



Sven Kristlbauer

Sven graduated with his BA in Animation one year ago. His graduation Film [“Gahts no Lang?”](#) is currently on a successful festival run, where it was able to win a few prizes.

Since graduation, he is now officially self-employed and trying to build up a career as a freelance Animator and Illustrator.

He has had an interest in game design for a long time now, participating in game jams and experimenting whenever he can.

Lucky Castaway is the first commercial game he’s working on, and he’s very excited to see where the journey leads!

Roles: Art
 Animation

Portfolio: <https://instagram.com/kritzelbauer>



Project Status

Philipp participated in the [Swiss Game Hub bootcamp](#), where he was mentored from picking an idea with great potential for commercial success up until the completion of *Lucky Castaway*'s early prototype. Feedback from early playtests has been very positive, both in-person and online on [itch.io](#).

At the time of writing (August 22nd), the organizers of the bootcamp (Philomena Schwab of Stray Fawn Studio and Thomas Gervraud, creator of Brotato) have already reached out to content creators who are going to play the prototype. This should result in helpful insights and highlight aspects that can be improved. Additionally, analyzing the resulting traffic on the game's itch-page will help with estimating the general interest in the game.

The next big goal is to finish the pre-production phase with a polished vertical slice of the game and publish it as a demo on Steam.

Design Pillars

Tension between luck and agency	Lighthearted and Playful
Interesting decisions that balance risk and reward.	The overall tone and mood of the game.
Easy to learn, hard to master	Expandability
Simple rules but strategic depth.	Structuring content in a sensible way that allows for easy expansion.

Core Gameplay Loop

The core gameplay loop consists of two alternating phases. The player will strategize and prepare in the first phase and then see the fruits of their labour in the second phase.

Phase 1: Preparation

There is no immediate danger during this phase, allowing the player to carefully prepare for the next encounter.



Explore

You can move sideways and upwards on the map (within the slot machine), either by clicking the arrow buttons on the slot machine or by using the arrow keys or A/W/D on the keyboard. Items and enemies on the map can be inspected by hovering over them.

Your goal is to reach the end of the map and each step upwards counts towards that goal.

Gather

If you run into an item you automatically pick it up and add it to your inventory. But be thoughtful about what you pick up, especially when you already own 20 items or more!

Craft

In the crafting panel you have access to 4 crafting slots. Each slot allows you to:

- **Start a new Recipe:** Spend 1 idea to start crafting a new recipe. You get to choose 1 out of 3 random recipes.
- **Add ingredients to the current recipe:** The current recipe tells you what resources are required to craft the item. All suitable ingredients from your inventory are highlighted when you hover over the crafting slot. Drag and drop suitable ingredients onto the crafting slot to spend them. The item is crafted and added to your inventory once all resource requirements are met. Recipes are one-time-use only, meaning the crafting slot will be empty afterwards.
- **Discard the current recipe:** If you don't like the current recipe, you can always discard it, immediately freeing up the crafting slot. You don't get back any spent ingredients when discarding a recipe. In fact, you can get rid of unwanted items by using them for crafting only to discard the recipe afterwards.

Phase 2: Encounter

An encounter is triggered when you step onto an enemy during phase 1. All you can do is pull the lever (by clicking it or hitting Space on the keyboard) and watch as the slots fill up with the items you have assembled in your inventory. Effects of items that appear in the spin will trigger, strengthening you for the exchange of attacks that follows.

Keep pulling the lever until either you or your opponent reach 0 hitpoints.

If you die during the encounter it's game over. But if you win the encounter you are awarded with new ideas to start crafting more items.



Content and Metaprogression

The prototype in its current state only covers the core gameplay loop.

But eventually we want the game to have a roguelike progression system, meaning new content will be unlocked after each run. Unlockable content comes in the form of:

- **Islands:** These are the game's levels. We are planning at least 3 different islands for the full release of the game, but the demo will only include the first island. New islands will come with their own unique look and also alter the appearance of the slot machine. They will also feature different resource types (e.g. mushrooms, eggs, etc.) and introduce new recipes that use those resources. Naturally there will also be a different set of encounters on a new island.
- **Recipes:** A smaller reward are new recipes the player may encounter on future runs. This also allows us to position recipes for items with more advanced effects behind later unlocks, smoothing out the learning curve of the game.

What makes the game fun?

Problem Solving

Intellectual problem solving in the form of deckbuilding and resource management is one of the main drivers of the game's enjoyment.

Thrill of testing your luck

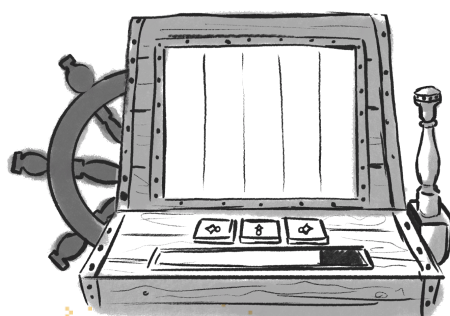
After preparing their inventory, the player's fate depends on the pull of the slot machine's lever. The excitement and adrenaline of this experience contributes greatly to the game's fun!

Satisfying VFX and SFX

The game's visual effects and sound effects make it intrinsically fun to play. The player is rewarded with especially satisfying effects when building synergies and managing to meet difficult conditions to trigger powerful effects! The fact that these effects will not trigger with every spin makes it even more satisfying when they do!

Metaprogression

The roguelite nature of the game offers extrinsic rewards - new recipes and islands to unlock! Even a run that ended in a game over should motivate the player to try again due to new unlocks!



Use of Funds

We intend to use the pre-production funds to **create a polished vertical slice of the game and publish it as a demo on Steam**. The following chapters show what we have in mind.

Structures

We would like the player to build up their camp over the course of a run. Each structure that is added to the camp will offer unique benefits or might even change some of the game's rules. The camp will offer a second layer of synergies in addition to the items, which will increase the game's depth. Functionally the camp would be comparable to *Relics* from *Slay the Spire*.



Production Quality

We would like to work on the following things to deliver a polished experience:

- **Art:** Create custom art assets. Currently, we rely on an asset pack, mainly for the items inside of the slot machine. In the future, all of the art will be original.
- **Animation:** Breathe life into characters by giving them simple spritesheet animations. We also want to add cutscenes for the beginning and end.
- **Audio:** Improve the audio (music and sound effects)
- **Balancing:** Frequent playtesting and data analysis will help us improve the game's balance and ensure that many build paths can lead to victory.
- **Various:** Tutorial, Island-Select screen (with only the first island unlocked in the demo), options (general, graphics and audio settings), a main menu (with direct Steam Wishlist option)

Content Variety

The early prototype does not yet feature structures and it also lacks variety both in enemies and items. We want to add enough variety for all these elements.

	Items	Enemies	Structures
Early Prototype (Sep 1st 2025)	 124 items 4 categories of item effects	 3 normal enemies 0 bosses enemies are very similar	 not implemented
Steam Demo (Apr 1st 2026)	124 different items 8 categories of item effects	10 normal enemies 3 bosses enemies have unique abilities	20 structures 5 categories of structure effects



Tone & Aesthetics

Being stranded with a slot machine is a rather silly premise that already sets the expectation for a game that does not take itself too seriously.

This is underlined by the slot machine itself, which is “dressed up” and becomes the player character’s friend, reminiscent of the iconic *Wilson* from the movie *Cast Away*.

Overall the game will be lighthearted and playful in tone, without sacrificing any strategic depth.

Pixel Art is the chosen art style, with the default sprite size for items and characters being 32 by 32 pixels. This sprite size is just big enough to add detail that brings life to the game’s world, but is still small enough to give it a distinct “Pixel Art” look. Furthermore this size allows for relatively fast production.

The game uses a bright color palette and includes especially flashy effects within the slot machine that make it feel upbeat and arcade-y.



Inspirations

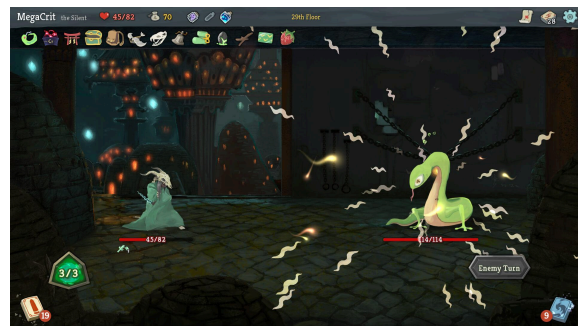
Luck be a Landlord

This game could be called the origin of the slot machine roguelike. It is definitely a great inspiration to us, mainly from a gameplay perspective.



Slay the Spire

Slay the Spire's masterful design and balancing inspires us to create an equally engaging experience.



Cast Away (Movie, 2000)

The iconic volleyball "Wilson" from the movie Cast Away inspired the decision to breathe life into the slot machine, making it the main character's friend.



Marketing

The mentors of the Swiss Game Hub bootcamp stressed that the choice of genre and the scope of the project are two extremely important aspects when it comes to making a commercially successful indie game. *Lucky Castaway* should be off to a good start in this regard:

- Choice of genre:** Roguelike/Roguelite Deckbuilders as well as Crafting games are very popular on Steam in general. The “Slot Machine Roguelike” is a relatively new subgenre that offers room for more entries.
 The game *Spin Hero*, which was released in October 2024, has over 500 reviews at the time of writing, but only 76% positive reviews. According to Philomena Schwab, marketing manager of Stray Fawn Studio, this is a great sign. The audience is there!
- Scope of the project:** A game’s revenue is not directly proportionate to its time in development. Smaller games are less expensive to make, which means less financial risk. They are also less at risk of becoming irrelevant by the time of release due to changes in the market.
Lucky Castaway will be rather small in scope and aims for a short development time of 16 months for these reasons.

Apart from these early and impactful decisions, *Lucky Castaway*’s marketing plan includes:

- Prototype on Itch:** Releasing the game’s early prototype on itch.io to get early feedback and analytics. This will already happen in September 2025.
- Discord-Community:** A discord server for *Lucky Castaway* has already been set up, so that a community of players (of the prototype on itch, and later Steam) can form organically. If there are hardcore-fans, then they are likely to join the discord server, provide valuable feedback, and they may even volunteer as beta-testers later on.
- Free Demo:** Releasing a free demo on Steam by the end of the pre-production phase.
- Content Creators:** During the Swiss Game Hub’s bootcamp we have already created a list of content creators who are known for playing similar games. We want to start reaching out to creators with smaller audiences who can provide helpful insights on how the game might be improved and to gauge overall interest. As the game matures, content creators with larger audiences will be contacted, making the game more publicly known.
- Steam Festivals:** Participation in the **Steam Deckbuilding Fest** (May 4th - May 11th 2026) and other fitting themed Steam festivals.
 Participation in the **Steam Next Fest** that is closest to the game’s launch.
- Social Media:** Posting about the game on social media (TikTok, Instagram, X, BlueSky, Reddit)

Target Audience

Lucky Castaway is for PC gamers who engage with indie games on Steam. It appeals to roguelike deckbuilding and strategy fans, who might have played games like *Luck be a Landlord*, *Cat God Ranch* or *Slay the Spire*.

The average player might be a mid-core indie gamer between 15 and 35 years old. Their main motivations are:

- **Mastery:** They enjoy strategic decision making, pulling off synergies or combos and taking on a challenge
- **Creativity:** They like experimenting with different builds
- **Fantasy:** They enjoy a playful take on the survival / crafting theme

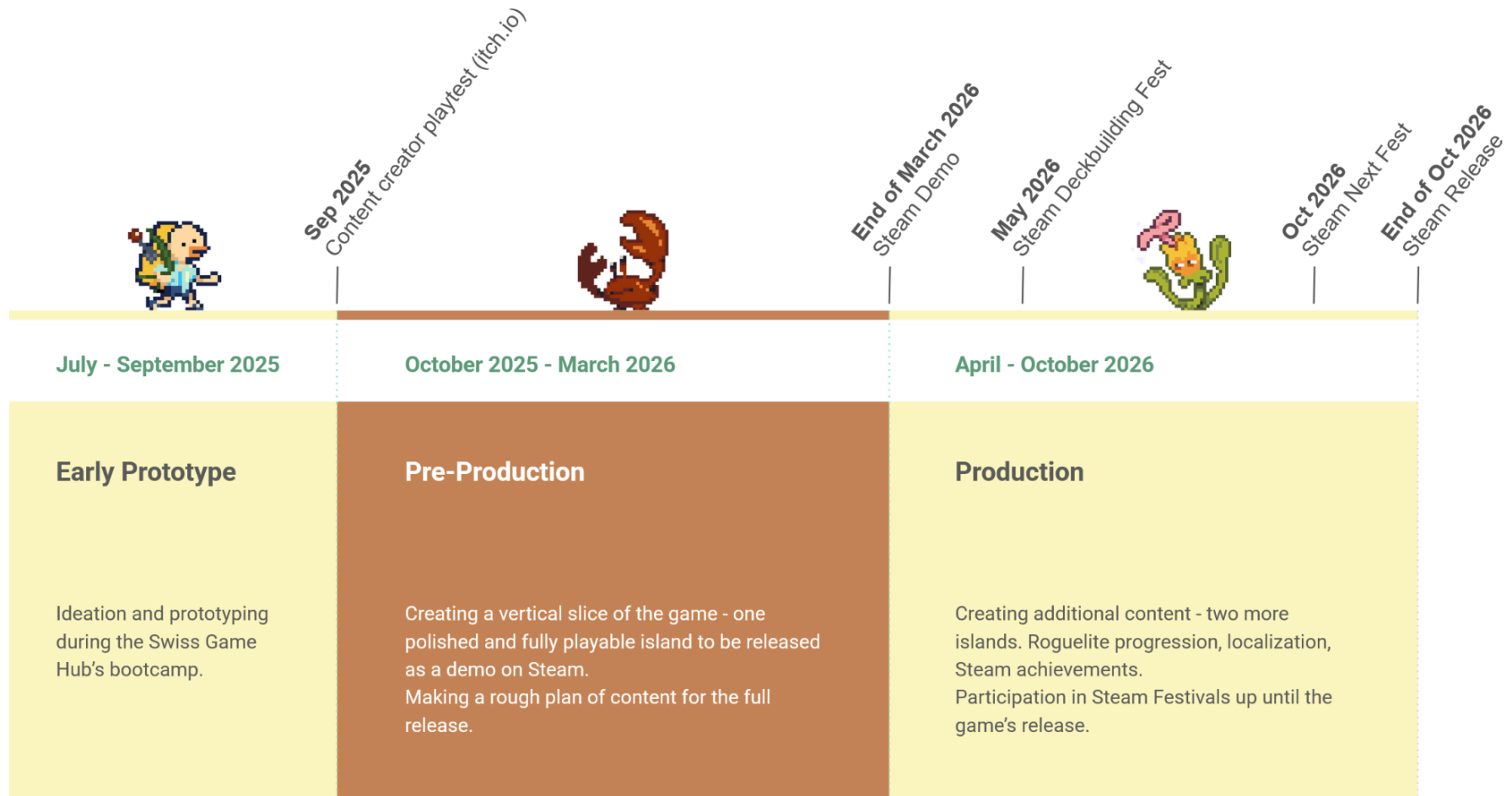
Market Analysis

Game	Release Date	Price Tag	Gross Revenue*	Reviews	Positive Reviews (%)	(Sub-)Genres			
						Deck-builder	Strategy	Roguelike	Slot Machine **
Luck be a Landlord	Jan 2023 (Full Release)	CHF 11	2.1M	9637	93%	x	x	x	x
Crop Rotation	Sep 2023	CHF 11	111k	486	94%	x	x	x	x
Cat God Ranch	Sep 2024	CHF 11	426k	1630	93%	x	x	x	x
Spin Hero	Oct 2024	CHF 9	93k	505	76%	x	x	x	x
Endgame of Devil	Apr 2023	CHF 7.75	151k	938	88%	x	x	x	x
Lucky Hero	Nov 2023	CHF 12.20	23.8k	77	87%	x	x	x	x
CloverPit DEMO	Apr 2025	-	-	-	-	x	x	x	x
Spinny Dungeon DEMO	Jun 2025	-	-	-	-	x	x	x	x
Peglin	Aug 2024	CHF 22	9.4M	9393	88%	x	x	x	
Dungeon Clawler	Nov 2024	CHF 11	1.3M	1642	92%	x	x	x	
Ballionaire	Dec 2024	CHF 12.34	523k	1840	85%	x	x	x	

* <https://vginsights.com/>

** Each round, the symbols (or items, animals, plants, etc.) in the player's deck are randomly distributed on a limited number of spaces, where their effects are then triggered. Synergies often revolve around symbols landing in a space that is adjacent (or in the same row / column) to another symbol. Most games thematically use a slot machine for this game mechanic. However, the games *Cat God Ranch* and *Crop Rotation* make use of the same game mechanic without presenting it as a slot machine.

Roadmap



CVs

Philipp Gröbelbauer		
Professional Experience	2025 - now	Indie Game Developer and Founder of Rare Crab Studio GmbH
	2020 - 2024	Web Developer at University of Zurich
	2018 - 2019	Software Developer at Pickwings AG
Education	2015 - 2018	Bachelor of Science in Computer Science / Studies at Hochschule Luzern
	2013 - 2015	Informatiker EFZ / Apprenticeship at Roche Diagnostics International AG
Personal Details	Name Address Phone E-Mail Date of Birth Nationality	Philipp Gröbelbauer Sandacker 14, 8052 Zürich +41 79 194 64 06 philipp.groebelbauer@gmail.com 31.12.1993 Swiss

Sven Kristlbauer		
Professional Experience	2025 - now	Freelance Animator and Illustrator
	2025 - now	Part time employee clip production EasyVote
	2024-2025	Internship Allrounder at YK Animation Studio
	2022	Internship 2D Animator at YK Animation Studio
Education	2021-2024	Bachelor of Arts in Animation at Hochschule Luzern
Personal Details	Name Address Phone E-Mail Date of Birth Nationality	Sven Kristlbauer Landoltstrasse 64, 3007 Bern +41 78 751 20 35 sven.kristlbauer@gmail.com 31.05.2001 Swiss

Budget

Please note that all salaries, costs and the budget are calculated for the whole duration of the project, not just the pre-production phase.

Overview

Income / Expense	Expected Amount (CHF)	Notes
Sales	165,000	30,000 units sold at 11 CHF, includes Steam cut and taxes (-50%)
Own contributions	50,000	Private investment Philipp Gröbelbauer
Pro Helvetia pre-production grant	20,000	
Salaries	-133,200	See table "salaries"
Non-personnel costs	-13,344	See table "non-personnel costs"
Total	88,456	

Salaries

Person	Employment Level	Months	Monthly Salary (100%, CHF)	Total Salary (CHF)	Social Insurance* (CHF)	Total Cost (Total Salary + Social Insurance)
Philipp Gröbelbauer	100%	16	5,000	80,000	16,000	96,000
Sven Kristlbauer (2025)	20%	6	5,000	6,000	1,200	7,200
Sven Kristlbauer (2026)	50%	10	5,000	25,000	5,000	30,000
Total				111,000	22,200	133,200

*AHV/IV, BVG, Insurance. Estimated as 20% of salary.

Non-personnel costs

Item	Cost (CHF)
Office Space	3,344
Marketing Budget	2,000
Music and Sound Design Budget	2,000
2x Unity Pro	4,000
Diverse	2,000
Total	13,344

THANK
YOU!

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